DSEH004 Performance Management and Employee Engagement

Week 8 | Lecture 2 | Unit III

Engagement Across the Employee Lifecycle

Socialization, embeddedness, plateaus and the shocks that start people leaving

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Commit before theory

Most people who quit say they left for more money. What does turnover research suggest?

A Money is the main reason, so match offers

B Many exits begin with a shock, and pay is the reason given at the end

C People leave managers, not jobs, every time

D Exits are random and cannot be predicted

The lifecycle as moments that matter

Attract and join

Promises are made; the contract is formed

Socialize

Role clarity, confidence and acceptance develop

Grow

Learning, recognition and mobility sustain energy

Plateau or move

Growth slows; the contract is renegotiated

Exit and alumni

Leaving well preserves reputation and return

Bauer et al.: what makes onboarding work

1 Role clarity

Knowing what is expected and how performance is judged

2 Self-efficacy

Confidence in being able to do the job

3 Social acceptance

Feeling liked and trusted by colleagues

Bauer et al. (2007): these three adjustment indicators connect socialization to performance, satisfaction, commitment and retention

Jones: two ways to socialize newcomers

Institutionalized tactics

- Collective, formal, sequential, fixed
- Experienced insiders guide newcomers
- Higher role clarity and commitment
- Less role innovation

vs

Individualized tactics

- Individual, informal, random, variable
- Newcomers figure things out alone
- More role innovation
- Higher uncertainty and early exit risk

Why people stay: job embeddedness

1 Links

Formal and informal connections to people and groups

2 Fit

Compatibility with the job, the organization and the community

3 Sacrifice

What would be lost by leaving, material and psychological

Mitchell et al. (2001): embeddedness predicts staying beyond satisfaction and commitment, on and off the job

Lee and Mitchell: the unfolding model of leaving

Shock

A jarring event: an offer, a slight, a reorganization, a life change

Script or image check

Does it trigger a plan, or a clash with personal values and goals?

Search or not

Some leave without searching; others compare alternatives

Exit

Pay is often the reason stated at the end

Lee and Mitchell (1994): the decision to leave often starts with a shock, not with slowly declining satisfaction

Plateaus: when growth stops

1 Structural plateau

No higher position is available (Ference et al., 1977)

2 Content plateau

The job no longer offers learning (Bardwick, 1986)

3 Life plateau

Work no longer feels central or meaningful

Structural plateaus are inevitable in pyramids; content plateaus can be fixed with lateral moves and new challenge

Losing people in year one

Teaching case (Course framing)

A Jaipur hotel chain loses 40 percent of new front-office staff within ten months. Onboarding is a two-day classroom induction, then each recruit shadows whoever is on shift. Exit forms list salary. Managers who stay longer than three years report few exits from their own teams.

Work it through

1. Diagnose using Bauer's three indicators
2. Which socialization tactics are in use?
3. What shocks might be triggering exits?
4. Design a 90-day onboarding with one measure for each indicator

Exam-style question

Using socialization, embeddedness and the unfolding model, design an engagement strategy across the employee lifecycle for a high-turnover service business. (20 marks)

What a strong answer does

- Identifies moments that matter and links them to the psychological contract
- Applies Bauer et al. and Jones to onboarding design
- Uses Mitchell et al. and Lee and Mitchell to explain staying and leaving
- Addresses plateaus and proposes measures for each stage

Sources

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